

Travel makes up a big part of our family's culture. We tend to travel fairly frequently. We try to make the effort to learn about different cultures and languages, especially in places where the family business is located. The first member of the third generation of our family (the younger author's son) was born in Buenos Aires, Argentina, where his family lived for three years. The older generations spent 15 years in France. Most of the second-generation children went to French schools and speak fluent French.

Another tradition of sorts we have is that, at family gatherings, a few of us play guitars and the rest of us sing along. This isn't a formal tradition of any sort. But it's something that we always do together. And that makes it a special family tradition.

All these things are manifestations of the family identity and the family culture. They reflect the unique style of the family. And they are each opportunities to expand and enrich the family identity. Family members should view these things as positive and accurate identifiers of the family. A successful family culture is one family members want to be a part of and identify themselves closely with. This holds the family together and helps maintain harmony because they have something in common that is held in high regard.

While all families have their traditions and their own cultures, one cultural feature is particular to Old Money families. They must learn the family business and/or the skills to preserve and create wealth.

Overcoming Setbacks

The Rothschild family is one of the most successful families in modern history. For over 200 years, the family has managed to stay together and preserve and grow wealth to astonishing levels. There are plenty of conspiracy theories about them. And there's much that we don't know.

However, they are a real family, also. They endure setbacks and pitfalls like the rest of us. The Parisian arm of their banking business was nationalized by the Mitterrand government in 1982. But they were able to rebuild in France, starting over from almost nothing. Because that's what Rothschilds do—they have the know-how and the connections to build